regulation. Abortion is widely available, and the state health care program provides it for free. Visitors are often surprised at the number of armed Israelis on the streets, but buying a gun is actually far more difficult than in the United States. While marijuana is technically illegal, you wouldn't know it from sitting in a Tel Aviv cafe. The list goes on. All of these are largely settled issues. Israel has its share of anti-gay demagogues, like one member of the Jewish Home who calls himself a "proud homophobe". But there is no serious talk of changing the status quo.

On the other hand, Israel still lacks civil marriage. Gay Israelis cannot marry in their own country. Nor can mixed-faith couples. Public transportation is largely unavailable on Shabbat—an inconvenience to middle-class Israelis, and a serious financial burden for impoverished ones. The Orthodox rabbinate has a monopoly on issuing *kashrut* certifications, a stricture that drives up costs for locals and tourists alike. (By one estimate, about 10 per cent of hotel and restaurant bills go directly to the rabbinate.) These are not simply abstract questions of identity; they have a tangible impact on millions of people.

Few prominent Israeli politicians seem prepared to resolve them. As the next chapter details, Netanyahu's party would win a plurality despite not even bothering to draft an economic platform. Many commentators would chalk this up to security concerns: regardless of what Israelis tell pollsters during the campaign, they ultimately cast a ballot based on their most fundamental fears.

But his victory would also demonstrate how Israelis vote based on, for lack of a better term, their tribal identity. Left-leaning parties like Labor and Meretz are seen as catering to European Jews; one Ashkenazi artist's racist comments at a campaign rally would quickly become a central piece of electoral propaganda. Unhappy Mizrahi voters would "come home" to Likud because they could not imagine voting for any party except the one that first gave them a political voice in the 1970s. Lapid, cast into the opposition, would prepare himself for a run at the premiership by embracing the same *haredim* he attacked a few years earlier.

The Knesset is somewhat unique among industrialized democracies in that it has no constituencies. The entire country is one big electoral district. This was a sensible arrangement when Israel was sparsely populated and relatively homogeneous. Today, though, it is a recipe for polarization, especially when coupled with the relatively low threshold for entering